King's Gambit Declined

ECO C30-C32 | 53 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Nf3 Bc5 7.Qe2 Bf5

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.72** (slightly better for White, depth 19). Best: Nc3.

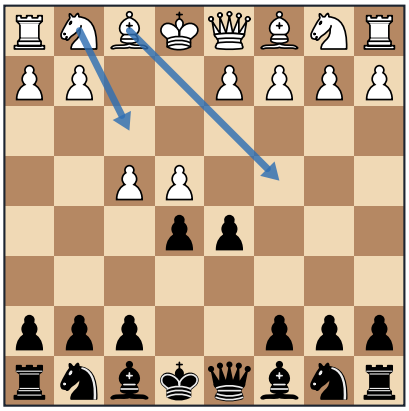
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Nf3 Bc5 7.Qe2 Bf5

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. f4	Attack the center. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... d5	Free the position. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. exd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
3... e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
4. d3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.
5. dxe4	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
5... Nxe4	Captures on e4 to trade or win material.
6. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
6... Bc5	Active bishop. Develops the bishop to c5.
7. Qe2	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
7... Bf5	Develops the bishop to f5.



After 1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5



After d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

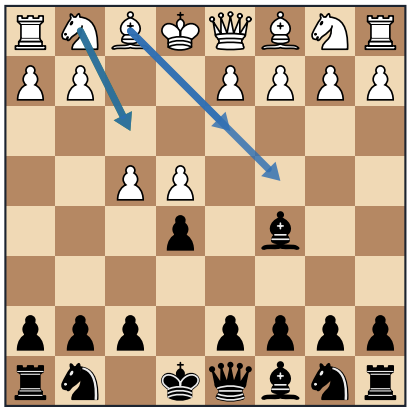


Position after the line

Falkbeer Countergambit C31 | 21 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5`

Stockfish: **-0.32** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: exd5.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Charousek Gambit, Anderssen Attack, Blackburne Attack, Hinrichsen Gambit

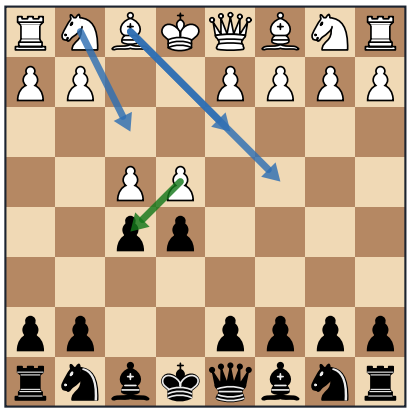


Position after the line

Classical Variation C30 | 6 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f4 Bc5`

Stockfish: **+0.05** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Euwe Attack, Rotlewi Countergambit, Rubinstein Countergambit, Walthoffen Attack



Position after the line

Panteldakis Countergambit C30 | 6 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5`

Stockfish: **+0.77** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: exf5.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Greco Variation, Pawn Sacrifice Line, Schiller's Defense, Shirazi Line

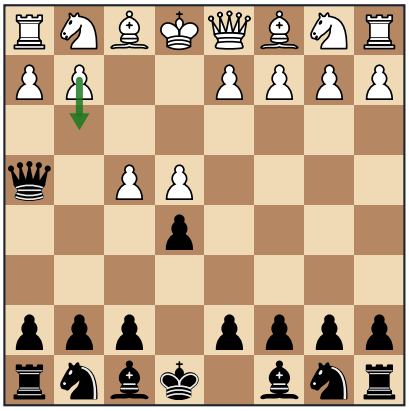


Position after the line

Norwalde Variation C30 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f4 Qf6`

Stockfish: **+0.94** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nc3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Bücker Gambit, Schubert Variation

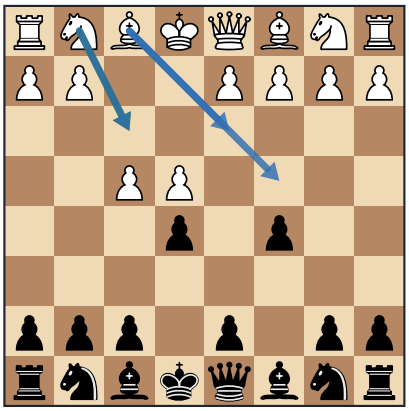


Position after the line

Keene's Defense C30 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.f4 Qh4`

Stockfish: **+0.71** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: g3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)



Position after the line

Mafia Defense C30 | 1 lines

`1.e4 c5 2.f4 e5`

Stockfish: **+0.50** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **King's Gambit Declined (all lines)** — C30
  1.e4
  - **Classical** — C30
    1.e4 -> 1...e5
    - **Soldatenkov Variation** — C30
      1.e4 e5 -> 2.f4 Bc5 3.Nf3 d6 4.fxe5
    - **Hanham Variation** — C30
      1.e4 e5 -> 2.f4 Bc5 3.Nf3 d6 4.Nc3 Nd7
    - **Réti Variation** — C30
      1.e4 e5 -> 2.f4 Bc5 3.Nf3 d6 4.c3 f5 5.fxe5 dxe5 6.d4 exd4 7.Bc4
    - **Svenonius Variation** — C30
      1.e4 e5 -> 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.d3 Bc5 5.f4 d6 6.Nf3 Bg4 7.h3 Bxf3 8.Qxf3 exf4
  - **Classical Variation** — C30
    1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Bc5
    - **Walthoffen Attack** — C30
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 Bc5 -> 3.Qh5
    - **Rotlewi Countergambit** — C30
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 Bc5 -> 3.Nf3 d6 4.b4
    - **Rubinstein Countergambit** — C30
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 Bc5 -> 3.Nf3 d6 4.c3 f5
    - **Euwe Attack** — C30
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 Bc5 -> 3.Nf3 d6 4.c3 Bg4 5.fxe5 dxe5 6.Qa4
  - **Falkbeer Countergambit** — C31
    1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 d5
    - **Blackburne Attack** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.Nf3
    - **Hinrichsen Gambit** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.d4
    - **Milner-Barry Variation** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.Nc3
    - **Miles Gambit** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 Bc5
    - **Modern Transfer** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 exf4
    - **Nimzowitsch-Marshall Countergambit** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 c6
    - **Staunton Line** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4
    - **Anderssen Attack** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.Bb5
    - **Charousek Gambit** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.d3
      - **Keres Variation** — C32
        1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 -> 4...Nf6 5.Nd2
      - **Old Line** — C32
        1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 -> 4...Nf6 5.Qe2
      - **Morphy Defense** — C31
        1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.f4 d5 4.exd5 e4 5.d3 Bb4 6.Bd2 e3
      - **Main Line** — C32
        1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 -> 4...Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Nf3 Bc5 7.Qe2 Bf5
    - **Pickler Gambit** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 c6 4.dxc6 Bc5
    - **Charousek Gambit Accepted** — C32
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4
    - **Rubinstein Variation** — C31
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.Nc3 Nf6 5.Qe2
    - **Charousek Variation** — C32
      1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Qe2 Qxd5 7.Nd2 f5 8.g4

- **Tarrasch Variation** C32
  1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Nf3 Bc5 7.Qe2 Bf5 8.g4 O-O
- **Alapin Variation** C32
  1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 -> 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4 6.Nf3 Bc5 7.Qe2 Bf2 8.Kd1 Qxd5 9.Nfd2
- **Keene's Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Qh4
- **Mafia Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...c5 2.f4 e5
- **Norwalde Variation** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Qf6
  - **Schubert Variation** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 Qf6 -> 3.Nc3 Qxf4 4.d4
  - **Bücker Gambit** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 Qf6 -> 3.Nc3 Qxf4 4.Nf3 Bb4 5.Bc4
- **Panteldakis Countergambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 f5
  - **Greco Variation** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5 -> 3.exf5 Qh4
  - **Schiller's Defense** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5 -> 3.exf5 Bc5
  - **Shirazi Line** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5 -> 3.exf5 exf4 4.Qh5 Ke7
  - **Pawn Sacrifice Line** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5 -> 3.exf5 exf4 4.Qh5 g6 5.fxg6 Qe7 6.Kd1
  - **Symmetrical Variation** C30
    1.e4 e5 2.f4 f5 -> 3.exf5 exf4 4.Nf3 d5 5.d4 Bd6 6.Bd3
- **Petrov's Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Nf6
- **Queen's Knight Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Nc6
- **Zilbermints Double Countergambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 g5
- **Falkbeer Countergambit Accepted** C31
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5
- **Keene Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Qh4 3.g3 Qe7
- **Miles Defense** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Nc6 3.Nf3 f5
- **Senechaud Countergambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Bc5 3.Nf3 g5
- **Soller-Zilbermints Gambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 f6 3.fxe5 Nc6
- **Zilbermints Double Gambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Nc6 3.Nf3 g5
- **Hobbs-Zilbermints Gambit** C30
  1.e4 -> 1...e5 2.f4 Nc6 3.Nf3 g5 4.fxg5 h6

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.e4 e5 2.f4 d5 3.exd5 e4 4.d3 Nf6 5.dxe4 Nxe4
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.